

Chapter 162-1

Investor. Joining a production with funding.

These two terms together made it hard not to let one's imagination run wild.

Zhao Xuning set down her half-finished beer and stared straight at Liang Shi.

Liang Shi: "?"

It seemed like a century-long stare.

Then Zhao Xuning turned her head and calmly watched TV.

Liang Shi: "?"

A few seconds later, Liang Shi gave a light cough: "What?"

Zhao Xuning's voice was flat: "Nothing."

But her usually expressionless face carried a hint of barely suppressed amusement.

Liang Shi couldn't help herself. "What? Are you doubting the truthfulness of what I said?"

Zhao Xuning shook her head: "No."

"Then what's with that expression?" Liang Shi took a big gulp of beer.

Zhao Xuning looked surprised and casually raised an eyebrow: "Hm? Is something wrong?"

"Three parts mockery, four parts cold indifference—you know what I mean?"¹ Liang Shi glared at her. "Right now you're not just similar to that person—you're practically identical."

Zhao Xuning: "....."

The slightly upturned corners of her mouth suddenly stiffened, looking very awkward.

"Even more alike now," Liang Shi said.

Zhao Xuning: ".....Go away."

Liang Shi stared at the message on her phone again, then said to her very seriously: "Don't not believe me. This is how it is for newcomers entering the entertainment industry. It's not like Sister Ying, who had backing and resources from the start. For small fry like us, when those big shots see we have some looks, they just... you know what I mean."

Zhao Xuning: "....."

"Power crushes people." Liang Shi scrolled through her agent's messages, then closed them, still thinking about whether to go or not.

Zhao Xuning was still staring at her.

Liang Shi got angry: "You don't believe me, do you?"

Zhao Xuning shook her head: "I believe you."

But her face showed no sign of actually believing it.

Liang Shi was already thinking about whether to bring pepper spray tomorrow. Just as she was about to place an order on the shopping app, a thought suddenly struck her—

"Zhao Xuning, do you think I'm not attractive enough, so no one would try to use unspoken rules on me?"

Zhao Xuning: "....."

She crushed the empty beer can in her hand, stood up, and returned to her room, leaving Liang Shi with a back that said "figure it out yourself."

Liang Shi casually grabbed a throw pillow and hurled it at her retreating figure, but it only hit the already-closed door.

"Zhao Xuning." As Liang Shi got up to retrieve the pillow from her doorway, she muttered a complaint: "Is it that hard to compliment someone?"

Zhao Xuning, who was in her room looking at Liang Shi's Weibo: "....."

"Sooner or later you're going to suffer because of that personality of yours," Liang Shi said.

Zhao Xuning's finger on the screen suddenly paused.

Those words sounded so familiar.

Even the tone was similar.

Back then, Shen Hui had also complained to her: "Is it that hard to compliment someone?"

It was just that when Shen Hui said it, there was more coquettishness and grievance than when Liang Shi said it.

Shen Hui's tone back then was much softer than Liang Shi's.

Shen Hui had said to her: "Your mouth is so pretty—would it kill you to say some nice things?"

Zhao Xuning often felt helpless with her.

She wasn't good at saying pretty words, nor could she do pretty things.

Back then, she was young and proud, full of vigor, always thinking it wasn't a big deal.

But looking back now, it seemed like it was.

She really had suffered quite a bit because of this personality.

Zhao Xuning lowered her eyes, looked up Liang Shi's company, and then made a phone call to a friend.

"Yeah, it's me," Zhao Xuning said. "I heard Huayi's upper management changed?"

The other person was startled: "Yeah, it was jointly acquired by Minghui Jewelry and Zhenghe Group."

"Minghui Jewelry?" Zhao Xuning was surprised.

"Yeah, that's Xu Qingzhu. You should know her, right?" the other person said. "Didn't she take over from her dad a while back? She suddenly reconciled with Haiwei Jewelry, and Su Zhe has been helping her with all his might. During that time, everyone was saying there's no smoke without fire after all these years."

"Xu Qingzhu is the daughter of Sheng Qinglin and Su Yao. Someone even saw her out and about with Su Yao." The other person summarized the situation concisely: "Now she's somehow connected with the Lu family in the capital, and acquired Huayi in less than a week."

Hearing this, Zhao Xuning said, "Thanks."

The other person was curious: "But why are you asking about this?"

"My cousin signed with that company," Zhao Xuning said. "Just checking."

"Sister Ying, huh," the other person laughed. "I can't believe Sister Ying didn't start her own company."

"She's too lazy." Zhao Xuning chatted with her for a few more lines, then found an excuse to hang up.

She had thought Liang Shi had really encountered the entertainment industry's unspoken rules.

Now she realized Liang Shi was overthinking it.

However, in the depths of the night, Zhao Xuning had a dream that startled her awake.

Drenched in cold sweat.

She raised her hand to cover her eyes. There were water droplets on her eyelashes.

She reached over to grab her phone and looked—1:20 AM.

Right when people were in deep sleep.

The house was completely quiet, without a single sound.

Footnotes:

¹ **"Three parts mockery, four parts cold indifference"** (三分譏笑四分涼薄): This is a famous phrase from the Chinese TV drama "Mo Shang Sang" (陌上桑) or similar period dramas, often used to describe a character's aloof, slightly contemptuous demeanor. It's become an internet meme to describe someone with a cold, mocking expression. The fact that Liang Shi compares Zhao Xuning to "that person" suggests she's referencing a well-known fictional character with this trademark expression.

Chapter 162-2

Thinking of that dream, Zhao Xuning dialed the number she had memorized for so long with trembling hands. There was a long series of dial tones...

Just when it was about to automatically disconnect, the call was answered. A slightly hoarse voice with a hint of crying said: "Hello?"

"Why are you crying?" Zhao Xuning's palms were sweating.

The other end of the phone suddenly went quiet. After a moment, a guarded voice came: "What does it have to do with you?"

"Shen Hui." Zhao Xuning closed her eyes, and tears fell onto her pillow. "I... I'm sorry."

Shen Hui paused.

Hearing those three words, she felt somewhat dazed.

Even when they were dating, she could count on one hand the number of times she'd heard Zhao Xuning say those words.

Even later when she had her miscarriage, she had never heard her say a single "I'm sorry."

Zhao Xuning's expressions and eyes had always said sorry, but she just never spoke the words aloud.

Suddenly hearing these words now, Shen Hui was stunned, her mind going completely blank.

After a long while, she finally found her voice again: "Zhao Xuning... don't you think it's too late?"

"I dreamed of..." Zhao Xuning's voice was choked. "Our little one."

"And also." Zhao Xuning let out a soft breath. "Ah Hui, I miss you so much."

The moment those words fell, the call was disconnected.

Zhao Xuning turned her phone face down and buried her head in her pillow.

She didn't make any sound, but the pillow became wet.

On the other side of the city, Shen Hui, who had hung up the phone, sat up in bed and suddenly burst into loud sobs.

In the empty, silent house, her crying echoed continuously.

So many things... seemed to always arrive too late.

The apology she wanted from Zhao Xuning, the yielding and bowing of head she wanted from Zhao Xuning.

She hadn't dreamed of their little one in such a long, long time.

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When Liang Shi went out, she brought pepper spray and waited downstairs for her agent on time.

As they went upstairs together, the agent reminded her: "If it's normal business discussion, we'll talk. Otherwise... there's no need. I'll be with you."

This was like giving Liang Shi a shot of confidence.

Seeing Liang Shi look at her in shock, the agent laughed: "What? Did you think I would just sell you out?"

Liang Shi shook her head: "No..."

"I'm here to help artists film," the agent said disdainfully. "Not to be a pimp."

Liang Shi: "....."

Blunt, but reassuring.

"Our company doesn't have that kind of culture," the agent said. "Ability comes first."

Liang Shi nodded: "Looks like I joined the right company."

The two went upstairs and walked toward the appointed location.

For some reason, the more Liang Shi walked, the more nervous she felt.

She had clearly seen big occasions before, navigating between major platforms, meeting plenty of investors, and being able to chat and laugh with them.

This wasn't supposed to be difficult for her.

But today her heart kept pounding, as if something big was about to happen.

Before entering, the agent reminded Liang Shi: "Be well-mannered. It would be best if you could fool her."

Liang Shi: ".....Okay."

"Knock knock—"

The agent raised her hand and knocked on the door. Someone opened it, nodded to Liang Shi and her agent, then left carrying some documents.

In the CEO's office, someone was nestled in a large chair, but with their back to them. The chair was too big to see clearly.

All they could see was that it was a woman with very long hair, very thin.

Liang Shi vaguely caught sight of the hair tips and thought they looked somewhat similar to Xu Qingzhu's.

The agent spoke from the side: "Hello, I'm Chang Hui from Huayi's talent management department, and I'm also Liang Shi's agent."

Her attitude was very good.

The other person raised a hand. "You go out first."

The voice was very cold.

Liang Shi found it somewhat familiar.

Hearing this, the agent frowned. "Um... business matters are usually handled by the agent. If there's anything, it would be better if you told me..."

Before the word "better" could finish leaving her mouth, the chair turned around, and that beautiful face with sharp, defined features appeared before the two of them.

Xu Qingzhu was wearing a light lotus-root colored suit with a white shirt underneath. Her entire body was buried in that large CEO chair, making her appear even more frail and petite.

Yet her presence was not to be underestimated.

Those eyes lifted slightly, carrying a hint of indifference.

Even after seeing Liang Shi, her expression didn't change. She just casually glanced at her, then looked away, as if Liang Shi was just someone completely unrelated to her.

The realization brought by that look made Liang Shi's heart suddenly ache.

She stared unblinkingly at Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu had gotten thinner again.

Before, this suit had fit her perfectly. Now it was slightly too big.

Xu Qingzhu casually picked up a pen from the desk. The pen seemed to come alive in her hands, spinning idly. Her face still wore that indifferent expression.

The office fell into silence.

Chapter 162-3

After a long while, Xu Qingzhu looked at Chang Hui. "I'll definitely work with you on business matters, but... do I need to go through you for the artist's personal life as well?"

The agent was stunned upon hearing this.

Good heavens, this was blatantly trying to use unspoken rules.

Chang Hui's expression changed slightly. She gave a light cough: "Sorry, our company's artists only accept business discussions."

But Xu Qingzhu looked at Liang Shi, the corners of her mouth lifting slightly with a hint of mockery: "Is that so? Liang Shi."

That cool, clear voice called her name coldly, without any tenderness or affection.

Only then did Liang Shi realize that hearing her name pronounced so formally and properly felt completely different from when Xu Qingzhu called her name in bed.

Just hearing her say her name like this made her throat feel sour.

Liang Shi stared directly at her. Their eyes met, neither backing down.

Neither looked away.

Chang Hui was someone who had navigated the business world for many years. Naturally, she noticed something was off between the two.

She could only stand there and observe how things developed.

Liang Shi closed her eyes, exhaled softly. "President Xu..."

Her throat was somewhat hoarse when she called this name.

Xu Qingzhu's eyes flickered slightly. Liang Shi looked at her, steeled her heart, gritted her teeth and said: "President Xu, have you considered divorcing me?"

Chang Hui: "?"

Chang Hui's jaw dropped open in shock, unable to close it.

Meanwhile, Xu Qingzhu sat in the chair, both legs trembling. Her hands gripped the chair tightly, veins bulging on the backs of her hands. She had been desperately holding back, but seeing Liang Shi right in front of her—

The completely uncontrollable physiological reaction made her eyes turn red.

She took a deep breath, but her voice still trembled. With shaking hands, she took out an examination report from the drawer and slid it across.

She had wanted to say those words very coolly, but when it came time to actually say them, she felt like her throat no longer belonged to her.

Her throat was tight and painful.

A few seconds later, she said in a choked voice: "I'm pregnant."

Then a slight pause, a breath. "It's yours."

The office was so quiet you could hear a pin drop.

As her words fell, tears dropped from her eyelashes.

Pearl-like teardrops fell directly onto her.

Seeing her cry, Chang Hui's professional instincts as an agent made her think: This is great material for acting! Even a fairy crying wouldn't be more beautiful than this!

Then she remembered: Oh right, these two were discussing divorce.

What? Divorce?

Chang Hui looked at Liang Shi, then at Xu Qingzhu, feeling like her brain couldn't keep up.

She opened her mouth wanting to say something, but didn't know what to say.

Xu Qingzhu had already turned away.

Liang Shi glanced at Chang Hui, and Chang Hui immediately understood. She left at once.

The moment she closed the door, a thought struck her: So the newly signed artist is actually a hidden rich second generation?! And she has an investor wife?! Who's also that good-looking?!

Chang Hui stood at the doorway in disarray. Her first thought was: With those conditions, why even enter the entertainment industry?

But inside the office, Liang Shi stood there, still at a loss.

This sudden news had completely stunned her.

After a long while, she walked over and looked at the report on the desk. The conclusion clearly stated: Pregnant.

Nothing could be more straightforward than those two words.

Liang Shi felt like fate had played an enormous joke on her.

But instead of thinking about the child first, she asked Xu Qingzhu: "Have you... still been having nightmares lately?"

Xu Qingzhu sneered and asked back: "What do you think?"

Her face was deathly pale as she spoke, her hands gripping the armrests tightly.

Liang Shi exhaled softly: "Do you... want to keep it?"

Xu Qingzhu's chair suddenly swung around. Those eyes, red like a rabbit's, stared straight at Liang Shi: "So... you want me to abort it?"

Liang Shi was stunned, then slowly shook her head. Her words came out strained and difficult: "Keep it."

Liang Shi leaned her arms on the desk and said gently: "This is our little one."

"What about you?" Xu Qingzhu asked. "Do you still want the divorce?"

"If I say we don't divorce, you'll die, won't you?" Liang Shi said. "Those frequent nightmares you had during that time, those days of mental exhaustion—they were all related to being with me... You don't want the divorce?"

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu stood up. Her thin arms propped against the desk as she faced Liang Shi eye to eye. "Then do you know what kind of days I've been living these past days?"

Xu Qingzhu looked at her and said, enunciating each word: "I've been like a puppet on strings. I don't know how I'm supposed to live. I know you have your reasons for the divorce, but so what? I don't want to cooperate with your divorce. Why were you the first one to be good to me, and also the first one to leave?"

"Do you know, this child almost didn't make it." Xu Qingzhu said. "After you left, I stopped having nightmares. Instead, I started being unable to sleep entire nights, crying night after night. Cry then sleep, sleep then cry. Eat then vomit, vomit then eat. Do you know how many days I've lived like this?"

By the end, Xu Qingzhu could no longer maintain her composure. She shouted at her: "What do you think is best?! I'm about to die, do you know that?!"

Liang Shi was stunned, and tears fell along with hers.

After a long while, Liang Shi walked toward her.

Step by step, slow but resolute.

Liang Shi stood in front of her, tilting her head back to force the tears back.

Xu Qingzhu opened her mouth, crying almost to the point of losing her voice. Her crying was silent—the kind where you're crying so hard you can't speak, yet you still want to make sounds, so some words get swallowed up.

"I've decided... okay... no divorce... I won't divorce you... even if you..." Halfway through, Xu Qingzhu's throat itched. She turned around, covered her mouth, and began to dry heave. Liang Shi patted her back from behind.

When Xu Qingzhu recovered, teardrops hung on her long eyelashes, making her look pitiful and heartbroken.

As if all her energy had been drained, she collapsed wearily into the chair.

Xu Qingzhu said: "Dying now or dying later—it's still dying, isn't it?"

Liang Shi looked at her and said with a choked voice: "You won't die."

"You were the one who walked in first," Xu Qingzhu said. "And you were also the first to leave."

"I didn't leave." Liang Shi couldn't continue either. She opened her arms toward Xu Qingzhu, just like when she had first returned from that world. Her voice was choked but gentle: "Baby, come here for a hug."

"We're not divorcing anymore." Liang Shi repeated. "Not divorcing anymore."